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Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1963-1966

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Place Coverage: Dobe Area, Botswana

Section Title(S): MARRIAGE

The favored marriage is with a woman drawn from the large category that ego addresses by the kin terms *tun* (older) or *tuma* (younger than ego). The *tuns* and *tumas* are the girls with whom ego has a relaxed joking relation, the female equivalent of the cordial "old name—young name" relation. Women classified as *//ga*, the !Kung say, are "like mothers" and the respect relation holds. Nevertheless, if the *//ga* in question is not ego's mother's or sister's namesake or a first cousin, he may marry her. Contracting a marriage with a family whose members are already in-laws of one's family is highly desired, and levirate, sororate, and sister exchanges occur fairly commonly.

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Men marry between the ages of twenty and thirty, usually after they have served a period as cattle herder for the Herero. Girls marry around the time of menarche, which tends to occur late, between the ages of fourteen and sixteen. Parents try to arrange a match while their children are still young, and one of the more pleasant topics discussed during intercamp visiting is *gau !xom*, or betrothal. Most of these arrangements go by the board, however, since the adolescents of both sexes often have ideas of their own. In current practice there is a period of unstable marriage when young people may have several temporary liaisons before settling down with a lifelong partner. Adolescent sterility makes it possible for girls to experiment sexually without becoming pregnant. Even if a pregnancy occurs, illegitimacy is virtually unknown, since husbands are always found to marry the girl and assume fatherhood of the child.

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The qualities a girl's parents look for in a son-in-law are hunting ability and a pleasant, nonaggressive personality. In order to prove himself, the young husband may serve a period of "bride service" in the camp of his wife's parents. However, with the fluidity of group structure, the young couple may spend as much as half of their time living elsewhere, as is illustrated by the example of tsaa and n!uhka (p. 355).

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While the Dobe !Kung permit it, they are ambivalent about plural marriage. In 1964 only 5 percent of the marriages in the Dobe area were polygamous. There were six cases of polygyny (and only one man had three wives) and one polyandrous household. Several factors would seem to favor a higher incidence of polygyny. There is no lack of surplus women; in 1964 thirty-five divorcees and widows (16 percent of all women over fifteen years) were living without husbands. Also, the economic burden of a second wife is not great, since it is the women who provide over half of the food for the household. The major obstacle seems to be the attitude of the wives themselves. Many men have said that they desire a second wife, but fail to take one for fear of incurring the wrath of their present wife. Married women threaten to leave their husbands if they bring a second wife into the household; and if a man does, in spite of his wife's objections, she may make life miserable for the junior wife and the husband ■ 359 alike. The women of the Dobe area, at any rate, would not subscribe to Lorna Marshall's statement that "Polygyny is the ideal form of marriage among the !Kung" (1959:345). A marriage to two sisters has the best chance of success, since the girls have grown up in a close cooperative relation: three of the six polygynous unions were sororal in form.

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